

**Dan Egan**

Chapters 7–8

WEEK 2 · MON 21 SEP

WATER QUESTION

What water do you pass most often without stopping to look?

The storm drain by my dorm.
I step over it every day and have
never once asked where it goes.

ARCHIVING What is here? Facts, ideas, style highlights.

Ch 7 - Black Swamp (CT-sized) drained by 15,000 mi of ditches + tile (p.215). Egan flips it: not a 'wasteland' but 'Lake Erie's kidney' (p.216) - a filter.
1960s: 24,000 tons phosphorus/yr = 'Dead Sea'. 1972: 11,000 tons + \$8 bil sewage. Walleye Capital again in <2 decades (p.223). Then the blooms return anyway: no-till leaves fertilizer on top, dissolved P +150% since mid-90s (p.228).
Mussels too. Aug 2014 Toledo: do-not-drink 1:20 a.m., ~500,000 people (p.239-240).
Ch 8 - water piped over the basin line 'never returns' (p.248). 2008 compact.
Waukesha: diversion approved 2016 (p.275). STYLE: 'a little like money' (p.228).

ANALYZING What does it mean? Who cares, who doesn't, who should care?

The swamp was doing a job (filtering); we drained it, then paid: \$8 bil of sewage plants (p.222), now Toledo's intake. Who cares: Toledo (~500,000, p.239), walleye anglers. Who doesn't: unclear. Egan shows farmers trying cover crops (p.233), so not villains. Who should: everyone upstream + whoever writes the rules. The Clean Water Act (1972) hit pipes, left farm runoff 'largely untouched' (p.231).
Also p.216: Tocqueville says 'Nothing is missing except civilized man.' Egan fixes the swamp = wasteland error but keeps the 'empty' shore. Who was already there?

EXTENDING What does this tell us about our world right here and now?

We KNOW the fix: 40% less spring runoff on the Maumee (p.243). No law makes anyone do it - 'the political will to execute it does not' (p.243). Same as last week: warning ignored, then a crisis makes it useful. Scavia's irony: 40% of US corn goes to ethanol. I never think about my storm drain, but it goes somewhere, and somewhere is somebody's tap.

DISCUSSION What helpful questions can we ask about this work?

If the swamp was Lake Erie's kidney, who decided to drain it, and who pays now?
Why did the Clean Water Act reach pipes but not fields (p.231)?
Is Waukesha a fair first test of the compact, or a precedent problem (p.276)?

VOCABULARY WORDS

phosphorus · microcystin · watershed
nonpoint pollution · tile drain · compact

FEELINGS EVOKED

Wants relief (1972 worked), then
the floor drops (Toledo, no tap water).
On me: unease. The fix exists, unused.

